22,000. Hundreds of thousands of people became homeless, entire villages were wiped out, and ancient temples in central Kathmandu were damaged. Both China and India, along with many other countries, provided assistance to the victims, but coupled with the blockade, 2015 was the worst year in Nepal's modern history. As a result of the blockade, there was a shortage of daily commodities, including fuel, in an already ravaged country.

After many Nepalese had blamed the blockade on India, which had criticized the lack of inclusiveness in the new constitution, some politicians in Kathmandu now began to accuse India of fomenting the movement among the Madhesis. According to the ICG:

> India's domestic policies were also a factor. When the blockade began, there was a common belief that the ruling BJP [Bharatiya Janata Party] was trying to win votes in Bihar state elections by appearing to project the interests of the Biharis' kin across the border. This fuelled the perception that Madhesi and Indian demands—and Madhesis and Biharis in India—were interchangeable.[54]

India denied the allegations, but that was to no avail. When the blockade ended on 8 February 2016, anti-Indian sentiment was running high in Nepal.

The Chinese, meanwhile, were pursuing a more subtle, behind-the-scenes policy—and one of their main concerns was the presence in Nepal of 20,000 Tibetan refugees, some whom had fled in 1959. According to an article for *Jane's Intelligence Review* written by Stephan Blancke, a German political scientist specializing in intelligence and organized crime: 'Internally, Tibet remains a key operational theatre. In Nepal, where the Ministry of State Security has established various non-governmental organizations (NGOs) and language institutes, delegations of Chinese intelligence operatives regularly meet in order to co-ordinate operations against the Tibetan community.'[55] *Jane's Intelligence Review* went on to quote a 23 May 2013 press statement released by the Central Tibetan Administration's Department of Security which 'claimed that Li Yuquan, in his capacity as head of the Public Security Bureau of Nangchu Prefecture in the Tibet Autonomous Region, recruited a Tibetan for the purpose of spying on Tibetan NGOs, and later in order to carry out the attempted murder of two dissidents'.[56]

On an official level, China has provided assistance to Nepal for establishing the National Armed Police Force Academy and built a well-